The Ambiguity of Childhood in François Boucher's Pastoral Figures

SYE Art History Independent Study by Charlotte Childs

Liaisons set deep in the woods; couples playing music or feeding one another, unaware of an onlooker. These are the themes of François Boucher's pastoral paintings and biscuit porcelain sculptures.

In the Fall, I completed an SYE research project on ceramic figure groups inspired by the Rococo painter, François Boucher. They draw upon traditional pastoral subjects and, like much of Boucher's work, involve couples embracing. However, the figures look more like children than adults. These figure groups were made after Boucher's designs at the French Royal centers of porcelain production: Sèvres and Vincennes.

Two paintings by Boucher, *Are They Thinking of the Grape?* and *The Enjoyable Lesson,* were reproduced in several examples as biscuit porcelain sculptures. Although the subjects are agrarian workers – shepherds and shepherdesses – the figures are not focused on their work but rather on one another. Boucher presents his subjects at leisure, in a state of euphoria, and highly prettified, thereby distancing them from realistic portrayals of peasant life.

In my examination of this material, I was struck by the childlike appearance of these figures. Why would 18th-century viewers be drawn to images of children as adult couples? To find answers, I consulted studies of childhood and the education of children in 18th-century France. I also found sources on the ambivalence of subject matter in Rococo art as well as the broader themes of Sentimentalism and Libertinism. At the outset of this project, I read biographies of Madame de Pompadour, Louis XV's most famous mistress and a prominent figure in the intellectual and cultural life of the court. Pompadour, a leading patron of Sèvres and Vincennes, owned several of these youthful figure groups.

The Enjoyable Lesson c. 1748

The Flute Lesson c. 1757

Are They Thinking of the Grape? c. 1747

The Grape Eaters c. 1752

In studying 15th- to 18th-century Art, I have found that several ideas can be read into these images. For example, children were portrayed as young adults in Renaissance and Baroque Art. This is because childhood was seen mainly as a stage of training for adulthood. Further, Emma Barker, William Reddy, and other scholars, have identified a trend of Sentimentalism in the philosophy, literature, and arts of the period roughly matching the reigns of Louis XIV and XV. Imagery that was sentimental, nostalgic, or that otherwise appealed to the emotions, related to the Enlightenment view of emotion as the pathway to knowledge and Reason. But above all, much Renaissance to Rococo imagery is allegorical rather than literal. Symbols with erotic connotations, like fruit and musical instruments, pervade this imagery.

All of this reflects the ambiguous nature of Early Modern artistic subject matter. The distribution of this imagery through multiple porcelain figure groups was evidence of its broader popularity.

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